

BEHENJI

WHAT SONIA WANTS...

Land for Rae Bareilly projects

- NATIONAL PHARMACEUTICAL RESEARCH AND TRAINING INSTITUTE
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- CRPF RECRUITMENT CENTRE
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- HOTEL MANAGEMENT INSTITUTE
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NAEEM ANSARI

Back home in Delhi, the Congress headquarters went into overdrive with General Secretary Digvijay Singh leading the attack. He came armed with data. "Acquisition of 487 hectare of land was done earlier and Rs 9 crore has already been paid for it. Only 189.25 hectare is gram panchayat land and the villagers have all agreed to the land transfer," he said, adding, "I did not expect a person holding such a high office to act in such a manner."

Of course, the fight goes much beyond the cancellation of a rail project. Alarmed at Mayawati's plans to encroach beyond Uttar Pradesh—she has already played spoiler for the Congress in the Gujarat and Himachal polls last year and could jeopardise the party's chances in the coming elections—the Congress launched an offensive against her with Rahul Gandhi leading the attack. Rahul knows for the party to revive itself, it needs to win a large chunk of the 80 MPs from Uttar Pradesh. (Currently it has only nine MPs.) During the 2007 state elections, his target was the Dalit leader.

Initially, Mayawati did not retaliate; she was too busy decimating the Samajwadi Party (SP). After becoming chief minister she had a good rapport

with the Congress. She supported the UPA's Presidential candidate Pratibha Patil. Later, Uttar Pradesh Governor T. Rajeshwar withheld permission to prosecute Mayawati in a disproportionate assets case. However, as the regional leader's ambitions grew, they clashed with the Congress, more so as the two were eyeing the same Dalit-Brahmin vote bank. And suddenly the fragile truce was over.

Last year, Mayawati had sent a proposal to the Congress-led UPA Government at the Centre seeking a Rs 80,000-crore special package for her state. When the Centre did not respond, she plastered Lucknow with posters of what she had planned to do with the money. Mayawati also lobbied for SPG cover for herself. Though the Union Home Ministry sanctioned about 100 more personnel for Mayawati's security and allowed her car to ride up to her aircraft just like the prime minister, she was not satisfied. Instead, she accused the Congress of being insecure of her pan-Indian popularity.

The Congress appointment of a former SP member, Rita Bahuguna Joshi, as its PCC chief in place of Mulayam-baiter Salman Khurshid only

added to the mistrust. It was only a matter of time before Mayawati attacked the Centre on rising prices. In July, the CBI (read the Central Government) filed a chargesheet against Mayawati in the disproportionate assets case. She immediately withdrew support to the UPA Government. The Congress, too, lost no time in substituting her with the Mulayam Singh-Amar Singh duo.

Now with general elections round the corner, the acrimony is only going to get worse as the two scout for new allies and sharpen their attacks against each other. The fight is no longer restricted to Uttar Pradesh but extends to the prime ministership of India. An eager Mayawati sees this within her grasp. A former UPA ally, the CPI(M), is already projecting her as prime minister. Sonia is equally determined not to let the remote control to 7, Race Course Road slip out of her hands.

So the slugfest continues between two women who featured on the prestigious *Forbes* list of the 100 Most Powerful Women in the world this year. Debuting at number 59, Mayawati is anxious to bridge the gap with Sonia at Number 21. This is a numbers game, after all. ■